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Barrie Maguire's image of a woman stitching together the Irish landscape reflects the central question behind this Longer View: What will recent strategic spatial planning efforts in Europe give us? In the case of Northern Ireland, the quilt sewn from separate pieces of the landscape might represent that state's desire to establish cohesion while respecting diversity. Albrechts, Healy, and Kunzmann show that there and elsewhere, spatial planning efforts are stitching together new regional patterns for many parts of Europe.

Maguire is a graduate of Notre Dame University and comes from a family of artists. He has worked as a creative director at Hallmark Cards, a book designer and illustrator, and a newspaper editorial illustrator. Since visiting Ireland in 1998, he has focused on painting. He lives in Pennsylvania, and more of his work can be seen on his family's Web site, www.maguiregallery.com.

This article examines recent experiences in Europe in the preparation and use of strategic spatial frameworks to guide territorial development in city

Strategic Spatial Planning and Regional Governance in Europe

Louis Albrechts, Patsy Healey, and Klaus R. Kunzmann

In this article, we discuss the recent experience of planning and the development of strategic spatial development frameworks for city regions in Europe. We first explain the context and forces behind the revival of interest in this level of planning. We then describe three examples. We conclude by summarising the motivations behind the examples, drawing general lessons.

Rethinking Place, Territory, and Governance in an Expanding Europe

During the 1980s in Europe, it was often said that strategic planning was in limbo (Healey et al., 1997; Salet & Faludi, 2000). Instead, urban and regional planning practices focused on projects—especially for the revival of rundown parts of cities and regions—and on land use regulation. But by the end of the century, new efforts were underway in many parts of Europe to produce strategies for cities, subregions, and regions (Salet & Faludi, 2000). Often these efforts involve the construction of new institutional arenas within structures of government that are themselves changing. The motivations for these new efforts are varied, but the objectives have typically been to articulate a more coherent spatial logic for land use regulation, resource protection, and investments in regeneration and infrastructure. Strategic frameworks and visions for territorial development, with an emphasis on place qualities and the spatial impacts and integration of investments, complement and provide a context for specific development projects.

regions. It discusses the recent revival of interest in such strategic planning and the driving forces that create the momentum for it. We examine three cases recognised as in the forefront of this revival: the 1996 Spatial Strategy for the Hanover City Region, the 1997 Spatial Structure Plan for Flanders, and the 2001 Northern Ireland Regional Development Strategy. Each is described in terms of context and motivations, policy approaches and concepts, institutional arenas, impacts, and outcomes. The article concludes with general lessons from these cases and the European experience generally for the enterprise of strategic spatial planning.

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These efforts revive a well-developed capacity in many parts of Europe for government-led strategic interventions at the urban and regional level. Such efforts build on Europe's "strong state" traditions, particularly in the welfare states of the North West, as well as enduring political-cultural associations with city and region. This capacity is now being used in new ways to reposition cities and regions in the expanding economic and political landscape of the European Union (EU) and of globalising economic relations. These strategic efforts are also part of a movement to recompose governance relations, to break away from the functional/sectoral organisation typical of many national and regional/local governments, and to widen governance relations to incorporate in new ways significant economic and local community stakeholders. They also reflect a recognition of the eroding influence of national party politics in local political organisation and respond to reductions in national-level finance for local government.

The focus on the spatial relations of territories holds the promise of a more effective way of integrating economic, environmental, cultural, and social policy agendas as these affect localities. It also carries a potential for a "rescaling" of issue agendas down from the national or state level and up from the municipal level. This process may involve strengthening a scale at the level of broad regions, similar to U.S. and German states. Or it may mean strengthening a subregional development focus, the level of land and labour markets. A territorial focus also provides a promising basis for encouraging levels of government to work together and in partnership with actors in diverse positions in the economy and civil society (Fürst, 2001; Kunzmann, 2001b).

There are several driving forces behind these efforts (see Figure 1). Some relate to dominant policy agendas in the EU and European nation states. The influence of the "competitiveness" agenda has been widespread in Europe, underpinning much investment in infrastructure and urban redevelopment. The focus on city and region relates to well-established arguments about the importance of place qualities in economic development. In Europe, the environmental agenda is also strong, linked in part to the environmental movement's emphasis on sustainable resource use and in part to citizen movements concerned with the quality of life in places. This focus on place is linked in turn to a political-cultural momentum to reassert the importance of regional/local identity and image in the face of European integration and globalisation.

These motivations are complemented by the agenda of government reorganisation mentioned above. Forms of multilevel governance have a long history in Europe. Contemporary efforts at rescaling involve a double movement: to reduce hierarchies of levels while building stronger institutional capacity at regional and subregional levels, sometimes involving transnational cooperation. This is associated with the search for new concepts to drive policy integration (also called joined-up policy). *Sustainable development* has become a widely used term expressing the concept of potential for creating a positive-sum strategy combining economic, environmental, and social objectives in their spatial manifestation. *Territorial development* holds the promise of translating this concept into specific investment programmes and regulatory practices. This search for new scales of policy articulation and new policy concepts is also linked to attempts to widen the range of actors involved in policy processes, with new alliances, stakeholder partnerships, and consultative processes. It may respond to changes in flows of tax revenues or to concerns to rebuild connections between the state, the economy, and civil society.

- The “competitiveness” agenda, positioning city regions in a European/global economic space, supported by business interests.
- Changes in the financing of local government, with reduced national and local budgets, leading to the search for joint financing among public bodies and between public and private agencies.
- Sociocultural movements and lifestyle changes that focus voter and lobby group attention on environmentally sustainable resource management and the quality of life/environment in places.
- The reassertion of regional and local identity and image formation in the face of globalisation and the European integration project.
- New forms of multilevel governance and a government reorganisation agenda involving decentralisation and the formation of alliances.
- The search for new modes of territorial policy integration to replace/supplement the welfare state functional/sectoral organisation.
- The discourses and practices of a trans-European spatial planning policy community, diffusing principles of spatial development across Europe.
- A local response to pressing local and regional problems, articulated by local political processes.

FIGURE 1. Driving forces behind European strategic spatial planning.

The potential of strategic spatial planning to produce principles of spatial development that address the above issues has been vigorously promoted within the European Union by EU and national-level civil servants and their advisers from the various national planning-policy communities. This potential is especially evident in the production of the *European Spatial Development Perspective (ESDP)*. This document articulated the sustainable development ideal in a way that combined the EU's objectives of economic competitiveness, environmental

sustainability, and social cohesion (Committee for Spatial Development [CSD], 1999; Faludi & Waterhout, 2002). The spatial expression of this direction was the concept of *balanced development*, which offered the promise of development foci across the regions of the EU, while at the same time promoting the dynamism of the major growth zones on the continent. This general approach is developed through concepts of *polycentric development*, redefining urban-rural relations, securing access to infrastructure and knowledge (including trans-European communications), and at the same time promoting more compact development and resource conservation. The *ESDP* also puts a strong emphasis on encouraging partnership in governance forms.

Within the spatial planning policy community, at the European level, much of the discussion promoting a stronger spatial approach to spatial development emphasises forces arising from national, European, and global shifts in economic organisation, social values, and political organisation. What is less clear is the extent to which these exercises are a local response to pressing problems experienced locally and articulated by local political processes. This raises the question of the leverage that these strategic spatial planning exercises will have over time. They are, in effect, mobilisation exercises to articulate new policy frames and new policy relations. They tend to be associated with centre-left governments, which give more emphasis to strategy and to social objectives. Two critical questions must be asked about these exercises: What is their power to shape project proposals, budget allocations, and regulatory practices across a whole array of actors, both within and beyond the areas for which they are drawn up? Do they have the persuasive power to shift territorial development trajectories, or, as some argue (Kunzmann, 2001a, 2001b, 2001c), are they little more than a cosmetic covering that hides the growing disparities evolving within Europe? The European experiences provide a fertile laboratory to advance understanding of the nature and potential of strategic spatial frameworks and strategies for 21st-century conditions, but the above questions can be addressed only by looking at specific examples.

Innovative Exemplars

We have selected three cases, all of which are generally considered innovative, and all of which involve a strong local momentum. The first case is from the state of Lower Saxony in Germany, a federal nation in which states have substantial powers. More than 80% of the German people live in cities and their hinterlands. Most German city regions are searching for new territorial visions, sustainable development paradigms, and accept-

able ways of intraregional cooperation. Strategic spatial planning is a key component of political and administrative efforts in city regions to guide their development processes. The city region of Hanover is probably the best known example of the success of political efforts to raise the efficiency of strategic planning in German city regions. Benefiting from its status as a state capital, its relative economic wealth, its thoroughly pragmatic political culture and leadership, and, last but not least, its well-qualified and integrated professional administrative elite, Hanover has always been at the forefront of regional planning cultures. Although in Germany the term *strategic planning* as such is not used for spatial planning—rather, it is called *Leitbildentwicklung* (paradigm development)—regional planning in the Hanover area, in the context of established statutory regional planning processes at both state and city region levels, is visionary and strategic in its long-term goals and participatory and pragmatic when it comes to implementation. Hanover provides an example of *visionary incrementalism*, a solid combination of long-term visions and short-term pragmatism. Building on a long tradition of regional cooperation around spatial strategy, key actors in the city region of Hanover have been able to avoid the political marginalisation that has overtaken well-established spatial planning systems elsewhere in Germany at the start of the 21st century.

Our second case is from the Flanders region in Belgium. In the past, land use planning in Belgium has been relatively weak, focused around managing coexistence among individual development projects. Flanders, similar in size to a German state, has traditionally operated with a highly localised practice of largely regulatory planning, tolerant of dispersed development. The case represents an innovation, both institutionally and in terms of strategic concepts. It involves a transition from a fairly traditional regulatory land use planning system to the provision of a more strategic framework, from the practice of allowing dispersed development to the concept of managing growth according to sustainable development principles, and from rather closed processes to more open processes involving larger numbers of stakeholders (households, departments of government, firms, pressure groups, agencies, etc.) in the production of space and place qualities. Moreover, within an ongoing process of federalisation in Belgium, the case has helped create a clear regional identity and image for Flanders. Within Europe, the initiative has been recognised through awards from the European Commission and the European Council of Town Planners.

Our third case is from the UK, with its well-developed regulatory planning system but ill-developed arenas for regional policy formulation and weak traditions

of spatial strategy. The example involves the development of a regional development strategy for the Province of Northern Ireland. This exercise is the first in a new wave of British *regional spatial strategies* (Department of Transport, Local Government and the Region, 2001). It has been strongly influenced by the *ESDP* and is used within the UK and the European Union as an exemplar. It has been awarded prizes in the UK for its achievement. It has reframed policy agendas in the province, introduced the concept of a *spatial development strategy* into the UK and has helped to shift a governance culture. Its context, however, is very different from that of the rest of the UK. It arises from the very distinctive social and political context of a new hope for peace and devolved government in a divided society with a continuing experience of violent sectarian conflict. It therefore offers a striking example of the interplay of national and European planning policy ideas with the specificities of the local.

In the following sections, we present a cameo of the experience of each case. We discuss their contexts and motivations, policy approaches and concepts adopted, and the institutional arenas within which the strategy was articulated. In each case, we comment on specific impacts and outcomes, before turning in the final section to the lessons to be drawn from each case in relation to the wider European experience.

Effective Collaborations: The City Region of Hanover¹

Context

For more than half a century, Germany has benefited from a well-established multitier planning system, where legally based spatial planning is undertaken at the federal, state, regional, and local government tiers. Spatial planning at the federal, state, and regional tiers is basically physical planning. Each tier formulates spatial development goals and principles of implementation and assigns uses to space. This is done in a complex system of time-consuming, top-down and bottom-up procedures, following well-established principles within legitimised parliamentary decision making processes at the federal and state levels, but with little public involvement beyond the representative democratic system and the lobbying power of the private sector.² A strong constitutional system of federal devolution gives much legal and economic power to the 16 *Länder* (states). Accordingly, they plan the development of their territories quite independently from national ministries. The Hanover case is an example of policy formation through long-standing institutional arrangements built at the city region level within the state of Lower Saxony.

Driving Forces

The key motivation behind the effort in building the institutional arenas and practices of a collaborative city region was the desire on the part of the administrative heads of the three local powers—the City of Hanover, the County of Hanover, and the already-existing Intercommunal Association of Greater Hanover³—to change the established administrative arrangements between the powerful administration of the state of Lower Saxony and self-interested local governments. The protagonists aimed to modernise and streamline the administrative system in order to raise the city region's efficiency. They also sought to develop a joint approach to the location of city region facilities, such as leisure developments, logistics complexes, and out-of-town retail centres. Drawing on 38 years of experience of intercommunal cooperation, they anticipated the growing challenge of international city competition and developed a concept for a better planned and more efficiently organised city region. A further motivation was to make more effective and collaborative use of the eroding local tax base. Key actors also expected that a new regional entity would sharpen the external and international profile of the city region. The driving forces for change thus came firmly from below, curtailing the influence of the state-level government.

Policy Approach and Concepts

This alliance at the city region level focused on two strategic initiatives. The first initiative was a traditional comprehensive spatial *Leitbild* (spatial paradigm or framework), the *Regionales Raumordnungsprogramm* (Regional Planning Program). In 1996, this strategy replaced earlier strategies approved in 1967 and 1975. It was developed in a complex process of workshops and forums. It is formally embedded in the Lower Saxony *Landesentwicklungsplan* (state development plan). Based on a thorough analysis of regional strengths and weaknesses, different future scenarios were developed with alternative approaches to regional spatial organisation. This led to a single spatial *Leitbild* that combined the locational potentials of the City of Hanover and those of the surrounding 20 local governments. This strategy defined the pattern of settlements, assigned functions to spaces, identified locations for development, suggested intercommunal and interregional cooperation, and developed some ideas for regional mobility (see Figure 2). In 2001, a supplementary *Regionales Einzelhandelskonzept* (regional retail concept) was approved as a legally binding addition to the elaborated spatial *Leitbild*. This concept was the outcome of a 3-year effort by local governments in the city region to agree on the relative positions of centres within the region and on the locations of retail outlets, shopping centres, and big-box retailers.

The *Regionales Raumordnungsprogramm 1996* for the city region of Hanover is a strategic spatial planning document of considerable political importance. It was prepared through long discussions among the many regional actors. When finalised in 1996, it found unanimous political approval and has since served as a legal base for guiding spatial development in the city region. It has provided the information base for day-to-day decisions of spatial relevance. It is now being revised, as its legal validity expires in 2004. This revision provides the opportunity to respond to new challenges, such as the threat of demographic stagnation or even decline, the unequal use of public infrastructure, the continuing problem of decisions about out-of-town shopping developments, and the location of large, visually intrusive wind energy installations. Learning from previous shortcomings, the ongoing process will give much more attention to communicating the process of regional spatial planning to the regional public, via the Internet and easy-to-read brochures. In addition, the *Region Hannover* (described below) will intensify cooperation with the cities in the wider region in order to improve regional transport mobility, to agree on new greenfield developments, and to better control out-of-town shopping developments.

The second initiative, the forum *Region Hannover 2001*, was developed within the framework of the *Regionales Raumordnungsprogramm 1996*. This forum produced proposals for the production of a *Leitprojekt* (catalytic action area) for regional spatial development. The forum used the momentum of the World EXPO 2000 in Hanover to produce a consensual regional development strategy, the *Zukunftsdialog Region Hannover 2001* (2001 Forum on the Future of the Hanover Region). To identify suitable projects for the future of the region, the forum established seven working groups with more than 200 participants from the public and private sectors in the city region: housing in the 21st century, multimedia, life sciences, mobility, climate and energy, culture and leisure, and use of World EXPO potentials. They met frequently to discuss challenges as well as potentials and suggested a number of catalytic projects for public/private investment in the city region.

Institutional Arenas and Processes

Underpinning these two strategies was the creation in 2000 of a robust regional institutional arena, the *Region Hannover*. This arena built on the inheritance of the *Kommunalverband Großraum Hannover* (Intercommunal Association of Greater Hanover) that had been set up in 1992 (see note 3). It inserted an additional level within the existing multigovernance context of the city region (see Figure 3). When the *Region Hannover* was formed, the city region had a population of about 1.1 million, of

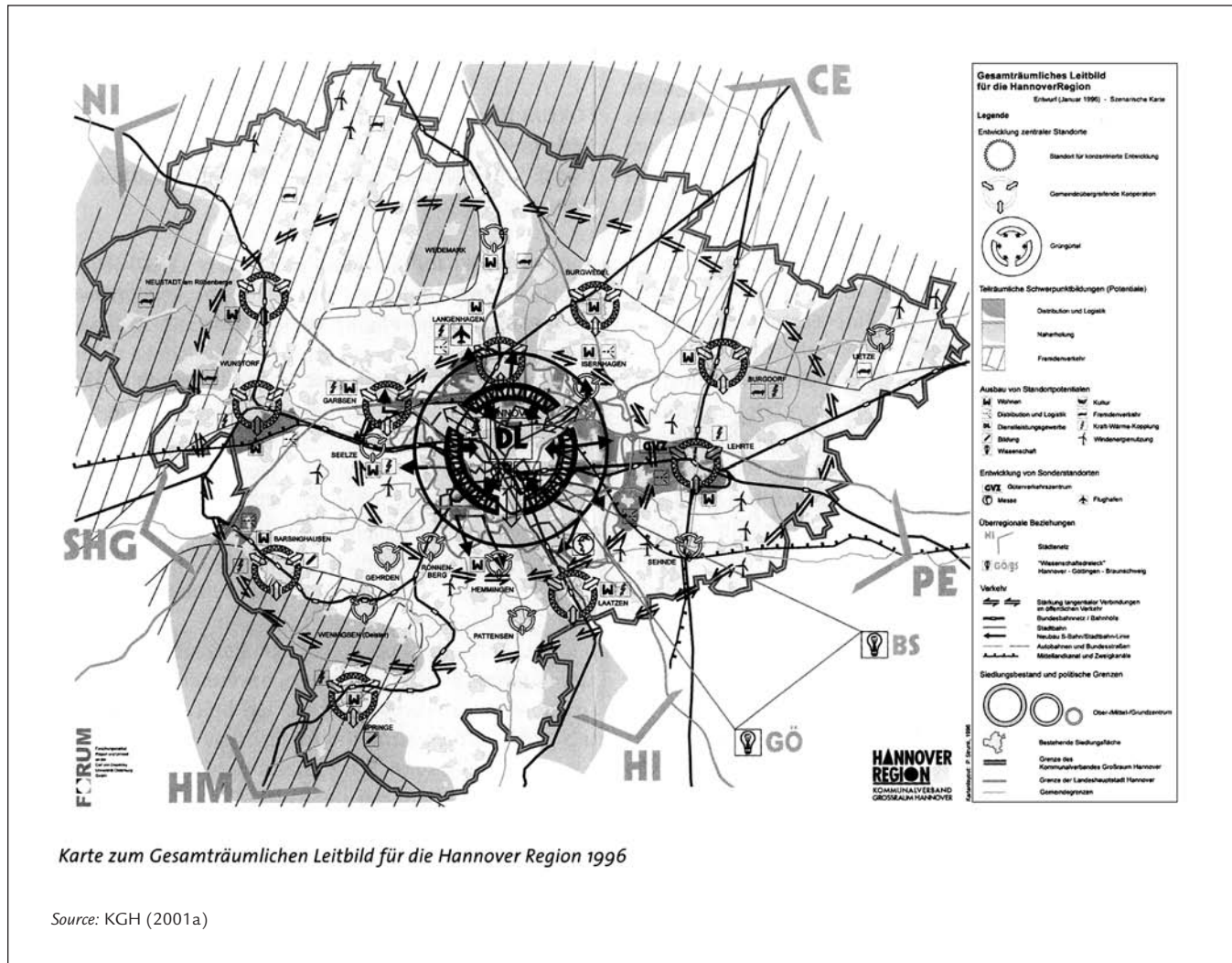


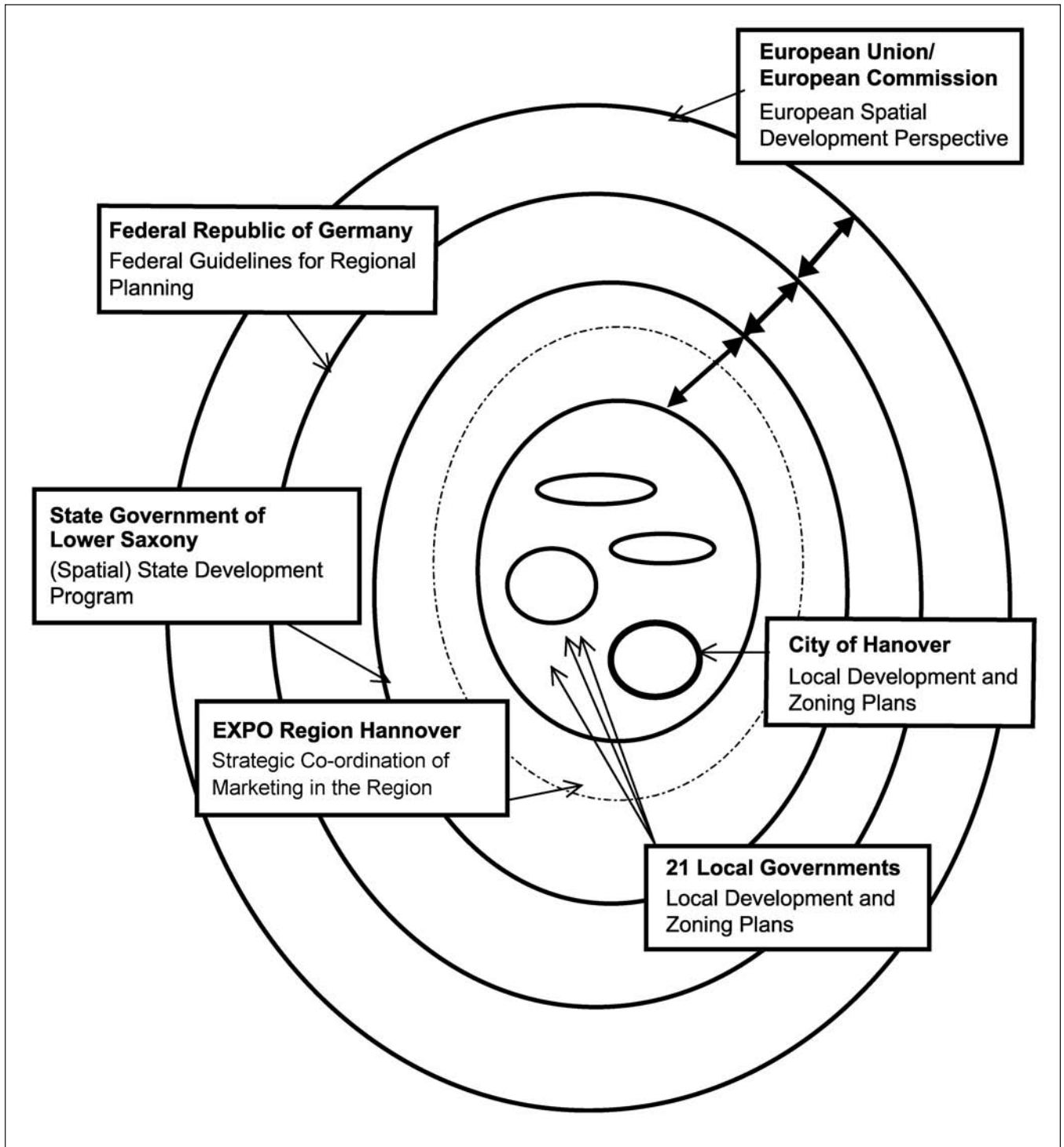
FIGURE 2. Spatial strategy diagram of the Hanover city region.

which around half lived in the central city of Hanover. The region has a president and an elected regional parliament, with legal power to approve locations for investment. The innovative feature of the new region is its division of tasks between the local governments and the *Region Hannover*. The compromise found after many years of political bargaining processes was a strengthening of both local governments and regional functions at the expense of the state government. This arrangement has built a strong tradition of collaboration that enables the elaborate discussion processes to proceed effectively. The city region “fathers” benefited considerably from the two initiatives described above, although these represent quite different approaches to producing strategic concepts for regional spatial development. Practices that

had previously been fragile and in need of constant revision had become part of a well-established approach that could then be built on in the future.

Impacts and Outcomes

In contrast to other city regions in Germany, the Hanover region has benefited from a long tradition of advanced regional planning approaches, initiated and elaborated by highly professional bureaucracies over decades. The rhetoric of competition for public resources and private investments among city regions in Europe proved helpful in speeding up the improvement of the regional planning machinery. However, it has been more the search for territory-based policy integration and ways to strengthen regional identity that moti-



Notes:

1. In a process of mutual consultation, known as *Gegenstromprinzip* [the countercurrent principle], the various politico-administrative tiers align their spatial planning goals and principles in time-consuming procedures.
2. In all tiers—local, regional, state, federal, and the European Union—parliaments define goals and make decisions. A complex system of sharing income and industrial/trade taxes provides all tiers with the necessary financial means. Local property and entertainment taxes play a negligible role.

FIGURE 3. Multilevel governance in the Hanover city region.

vated politicians and planners. The tradition of competent spatial planning in the region since World War II is an institutional inheritance that has allowed incremental institutional approaches to increase the efficiency of spatial planning and find broad consensus among the many public and private players and groups in the region. The European spatial planning discourse was of little direct relevance, since this itself was already strongly shaped by established German concepts. The support of strong politicians and civil servants for a regional approach has meant that the strategic concepts have been translated effectively into regional land use plans, thereby guiding public and private investments to appropriate locations while conserving landscape and natural resources.

Other city regions in Germany are eagerly monitoring the Hanover case and may try to copy its institutional solutions. Whether this will be possible, given the particular history of the planning tradition in the Hanover city region, its wealth, and a comparative absence of pressing problems, remains to be seen.

A Catalyst for Change: The 1997 Spatial Structure Plan for Flanders⁴

Context and Driving Forces

The Flanders case involves building strategic capacity at the level of a collection of urban regions. Since the 1970s, Belgium has experienced a shift away from a tight central state towards a new form of government in which the three regions—Flanders, Wallonia, and Brussels—all have considerable autonomy (see Figure 4). Spatial planning, housing, transport, the environment, and regional aspects of economic policy are now the exclusive responsibility of the three regions. Each region has its legislative body (parliament), a government, and its own administration. In Flanders—the second largest region, with an area of 13,522 square kilometres and a 2001 population of nearly 6 million—the local government adopted a three-level planning system (region, province, municipality), with spatial structure plans and spatial implementation plans at each level. The development of an overall spatial framework for Flanders as a whole had been on the political agenda for 20 years, but did not really start until 1992. In 1997, the Flemish Government approved the *Ruimtelijk Structuurplan Vlaanderen* (Spatial Structure Plan for Flanders; Ministerie Vlaamse Gemeenschap, 1998) with a time horizon of 15 years for the *indicative* part (variations only possible for very important reasons), while the Flemish parliament approved the *binding* part (variations require a formal revision of the plan). The spatial structure planning approach in Flan-

ders merges innovative local practices with new planning approaches drawn from academic arenas.

The impetus for the spatial structure plan was the widespread recognition of problems in the existing, highly dispersed spatial structure. Postindustrial reorganisation, suburbanisation, and the shift to road transport had disrupted the traditional pattern of urban networks in combination with a diversified but coherent system of valleys, woodlands, natural areas, and agricultural areas. This disruption resulted in an active and flexible but, at the same time, highly fragmented space. Elements of the past pattern survive against a background of emptying cities, diffused services, fragmentary networks, a damaged landscape, and high levels of road use. Urban development sprawls across the rural landscape. The politically recognised key to dealing with the spatial problems in Flanders was found in the frictions between the relative fixity of local conditions and the dynamics of global processes. What caused the tide to turn was the realisation by different sections in Flemish society (political, scientific, economic) of the enormous planning challenges facing Flanders. Located at the nerve centre of Western Europe, Flanders feels the full force of the spectacular restructuring of economic, political, ideological, and social relations that took place at the end of the 20th century. Growth pressures from Germany and the Netherlands spill over into the weakly regulated Flemish territory. Moreover, various sectoral spatial demands (housing, industry, transport, etc.) generate substantial additional space requirements⁵ and take on pronounced quantitative significance. To respond to these challenges, a new approach was conceived. The *Spatial Structure Plan for Flanders* (Ministerie Vlaamse Gemeenschap, 1998) became the basis around which new coalitions formed in support of a different configuration of policies, plans, and programmes and a new spatial concept (see Figure 5).

Policy Approach and Concepts

The driving aims behind the spatial structure plan were:

- to stop the ongoing deterioration of the environment;
- to give an acceptable answer to the space demands of the main sectors (housing, economy, nature, agriculture, and infrastructure);
- to change the existing (very negative) attitude toward planning held by influential stakeholders by establishing a new planning culture and shifting from passive planning towards a more action-oriented form;
- to introduce sustainability as a new basic attitude;

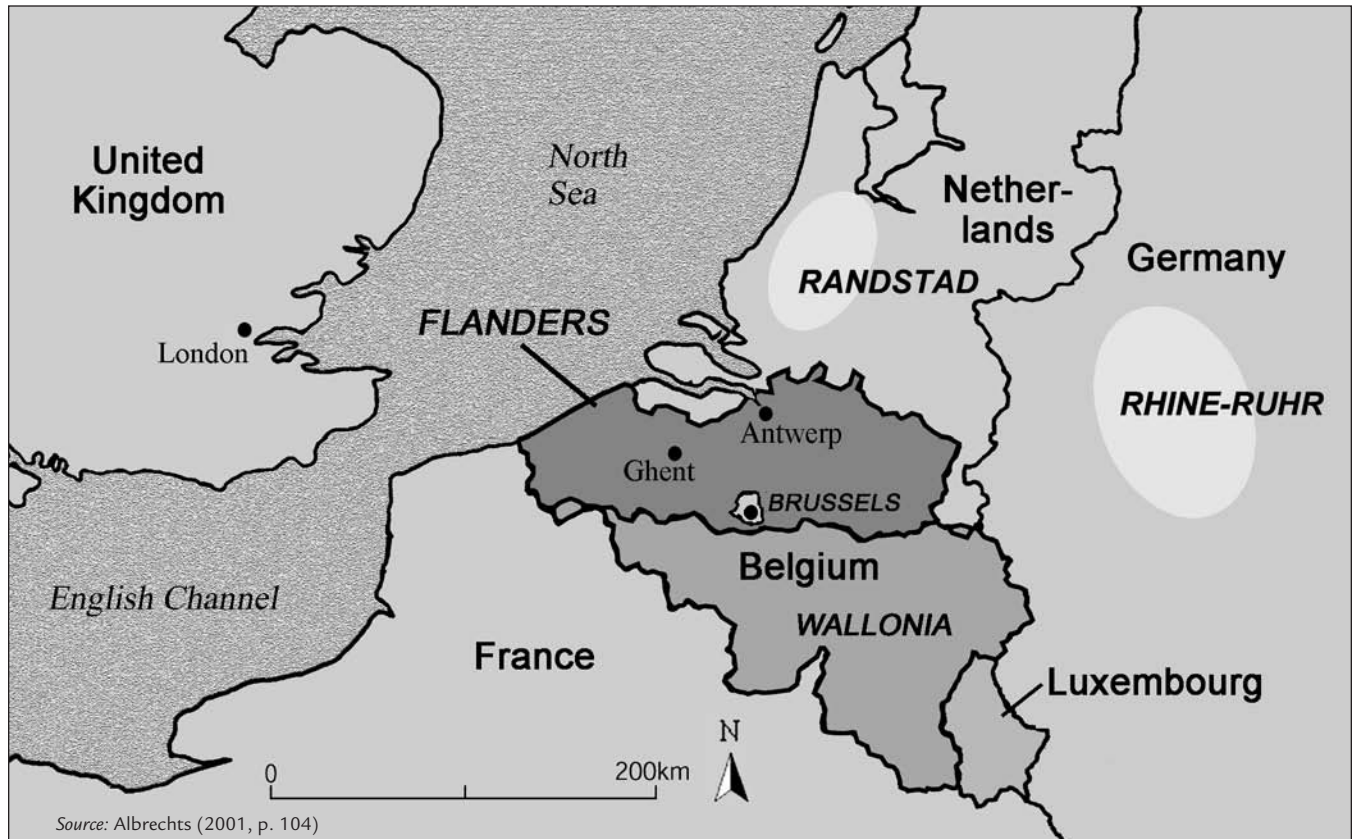


FIGURE 4. Flanders in North West Europe.

- to integrate key actors in the planning process;
- to introduce a completely new legal planning structure; and
- to provide Flanders with more adequate (spatial) instruments and structures for the fierce international competition it faces.

The spatial structure plan aims to provide structuring principles capable of imposing some order on the current perceived chaos. It seeks to find a new balance through a primary planning concept, *deconcentrated clustering*.⁶ This concept suggests a tension between dispersion and concentration. A second spatial concept is the recognition of nature, not as a subject of ecological concern or as a reserve but as an *ordering system*. River valleys, rather than any regulatory spatial ordering concept, currently maintain some articulation in the chaos in the periphery. The plan aims to make one coherent structuring framework from the river valleys together with linked open areas and corridors of open space. A third concept is the role of linear infrastructures as a structuring

framework. Categorisation of the road network makes it possible to set priorities: main roads with an emphasis on fast connections and a smooth traffic flow and local roads with an emphasis on local access; safe, slow traffic; and reduced traffic noise.

To make use of the central position of Flanders in Europe and to provide Flanders with the necessary instruments for fierce international competition, the planning team conceived the image of a “Flemish Diamond.”⁷ They argued that only by combining the complementary contributions of a network of Flemish cities (Brussels, Antwerp, and Ghent) would Flanders be able to compete more effectively for inward investment, within the European market as a whole and with other urban networks such as The Randstad, the Rhine-Ruhr area, and Lille-Roubaix-Tourcoing. Evoking these comparisons was a deliberate rhetorical device: The planning team hoped that by creating a common enemy, the different jurisdictions within the Flanders region would be encouraged to join forces and close ranks (see Figure 5).

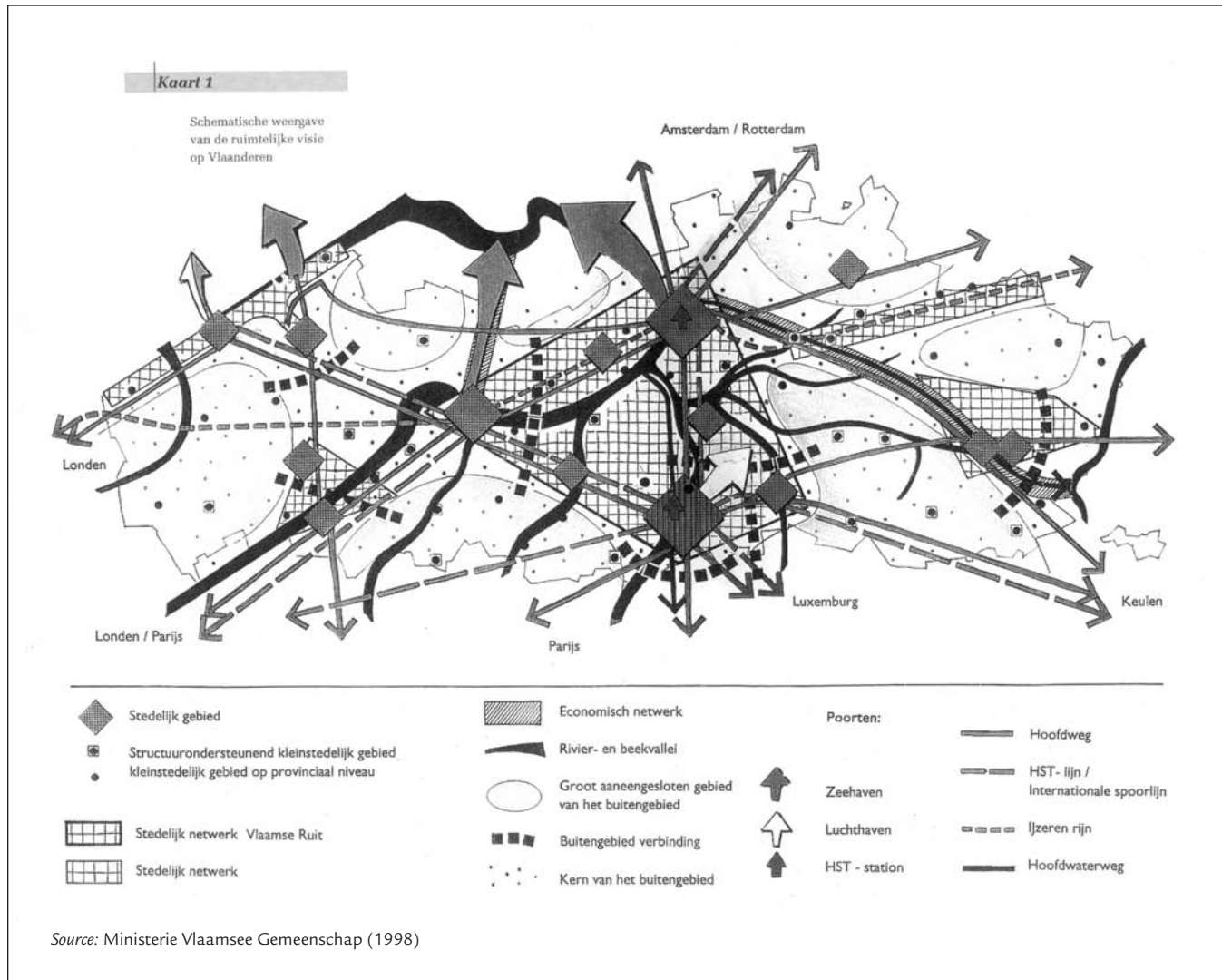


FIGURE 5. Spatial strategy diagram from the *Ruimtelijk Structuurplan Vlaanderen* [*Spatial Structure Plan for Flanders*], 1997.

Institutional Arenas and Processes

The strategic spatial planning exercise provided opportunities for discussing and deciding visions and key questions. It was not based just on traditional planning agency-client interactions,⁸ but took into account the specific politics of the area under concern—the institutional framework within which these interactions occur.

The open dialogue between the traditional sectoral departments (agriculture, housing, public works, education, transportation, and economy) introduced new people, alliances, networks, and ideas into the process. In this arena, a strategy was articulated. An important and very supportive actor was the trade unions. They

have members of parliament and ministers belonging to their sphere of influence, so that they have a direct impact on the political agenda. They organised special forums on spatial planning, in some of which the planning team participated. Through these discussions of the meaning and the impact of the spatial structure plan for workers and citizens, the trade unions became aware of the stake they had in it. Special arenas were set up for planning administrations and sector administrations at the central and provincial levels. These arenas were tailor-made for each administration, starting with the problems they faced and discussing how these problems may be treated through the principles of the spatial

structure plan. This dialogue proved to be extremely successful in making these administrations aware of what the new approach was really about and in obtaining more bottom-up input in an overwhelmingly top-down process.

The Flemish government commissioned the formation of the *Spatial Structure Plan for Flanders* (Ministerie Vlaamse Gemeenschap, 1998) to two senior academics, including Louis Albrechts, a co-author of this article. They decided to locate their planning team in the same building as the Flemish Planning Department. In doing so, they built an arena that allowed working for a structural transformation of the planning administration (both in numbers and in dedication to the new approach). This transformation proved to be one of the most important outcomes of the whole process.

Impacts and Outcomes

The *Spatial Structure Plan for Flanders* gave rise to remarkable learning processes, intense political debate, changes in mentality, and a much larger involvement in planning by local actors. Environmental groups and trade unions became strong and reliable partners against the dominance of traditional economic and agricultural organisations. Many sectoral government departments and local authorities have been overwhelmed by the spatial structure plan's process and are only now beginning to see the consequences of the plan. At the same time they have to absorb a new planning system, a new legal framework, and a different approach, and they have to professionalise to cope with new responsibilities.

The spatial concepts have been influential. They provided the discursive key that turned the discussion from one conception (dispersion) to another (clustering). Particular ways of understanding the "costs" of suburbanization (e.g., for agriculture, loss of productive land; for nature, loss of open space) changed perceptions of policy priorities that helped to change Flemish land use policy. Metaphors (e.g., the "Flemish Diamond") were used to illustrate the issues and tasks that were at stake. With the introduction of the spatial structure plan, planning has become more proactive. The needs and demands of all the stakeholders were defined both analytically and in discussion with some major stakeholders. All this involved a shift from a form of planning focused on the regulation of private development (i.e., traditional land use plans, which aim to provide physical solutions to social problems) to a form of spatial development strategy that seeks to work through the interests and strategies of selected stakeholders. The new approach works not by directing what various parties should do, but by framing the activities of stakeholders in an effort to help achieve shared concerns about spatial changes in Flanders.

In the new planning laws of 1996 and 1999, the mechanism of the spatial structure plan was introduced, and the approach applied in the plan has become the official planning approach.

Healing a Divided Society: The Northern Ireland Regional Development Strategy⁹

Context and Driving Forces

Northern Ireland is a province of the United Kingdom, with a 2001 population of 1.7 million. Sectarian divisions are spatially differentiated at the regional scale, between towns and villages and within the main towns (Belfast and Derry). Sectarian violence, known as "The Troubles," erupted 30 years ago, leading to the imposition of "government from Westminster" (meaning from London) in the form of the Northern Ireland Executive. A peace process developed momentum in the 1990s, resulting in the replacement of the Northern Ireland Executive with a new, power-sharing elected government in 1999.

The process of developing the *Northern Ireland Regional Development Strategy*, also called *Shaping Our Future* (DRDNI, 2002), has the explicit backing of the new UK Labour government.¹⁰ In enabling legislation, it was given a key role in developing a framework for coordinating the activities of the new devolved government to be set up once agreement among the various factions had been reached. Its role was not just the spatial coordination of public investment, however. It was also intended to provide a vision for a new, more socially cohesive and outward looking Northern Ireland. It was preceded by an initiative by the Northern Ireland Executive to prepare a plan for the Belfast Metropolitan Area. A Province-wide strategy held out the promise of considering the Belfast area, which was dominated by one of the province's sectarian groups, in a wider context of development opportunities across the whole of Northern Ireland.

The final strategy was approved in September 2001 by the new devolved government. Its rhetoric is filled with the double aim of fostering a cohesive society while recognising difference—of places, groups, and identities. The guiding principles of the strategy are:

- taking an approach focused on people and community (recognising the diversity of people and places);
- achieving a more cohesive society (based on equality of opportunity, spatial equity, a partnership approach that is respectful of the sensitivities

of a divided community, a more sustainable approach to transport, and an outward-looking perspective); and

- achieving competitiveness (based on investing in “intelligence” and improving accessibility). (DRDNI, 2002, pp. 22–23)

Policy Approaches and Concepts

Shaping Our Future, as developed through a *spatial development strategy*, tries to achieve the tricky goal of both focusing on the Belfast Metropolitan Area (BMA) and spreading development—that is, fostering both competitiveness and cohesion. The discourse of the *European Spatial Development Perspective (ESDP)* provided a valuable resource in articulating this conjunction. A focus on the Belfast city region is justified by the logic of competitiveness in a European context (making best use of regional assets). Spreading development is justified by the logic of achieving a more cohesive society (promoting balanced and integrated regional development). The spatial development strategy is articulated through six themes (see Figure 6) and two sets of spatial organising concepts. The first set of concepts divides the area into

three territories: The BMA, the area around (London)-Derry in the west (a regional hub, and the rural areas (a polycentric network of hubs and clusters). The second set of concepts develops a spatial vocabulary of hubs, corridors, and gateways, drawing on the *ESDP*. These concepts are drawn into a strong visual statement, which is unusual in recent UK practice (see Figure 7).

These ideas performed real political work in the context of building a legitimate and acceptable framework for the new power-sharing government. But in addition, the strategy has been influenced by other rhetorics and policy discourses, notably those of the *ESDP* and UK national planning policy. In particular, the planning team borrowed from these arenas the vocabulary of sustainable development, brownfield land targets, and allocating housing numbers to different parts of the province. The policy approach of *Shaping Our Future* is thus the result of the interplay of different discourses:

- a specific Northern Ireland political discourse about cohesion, diversity, and the balance between the BMA and the rest of the province;
- the concepts developed in the *ESDP*; and

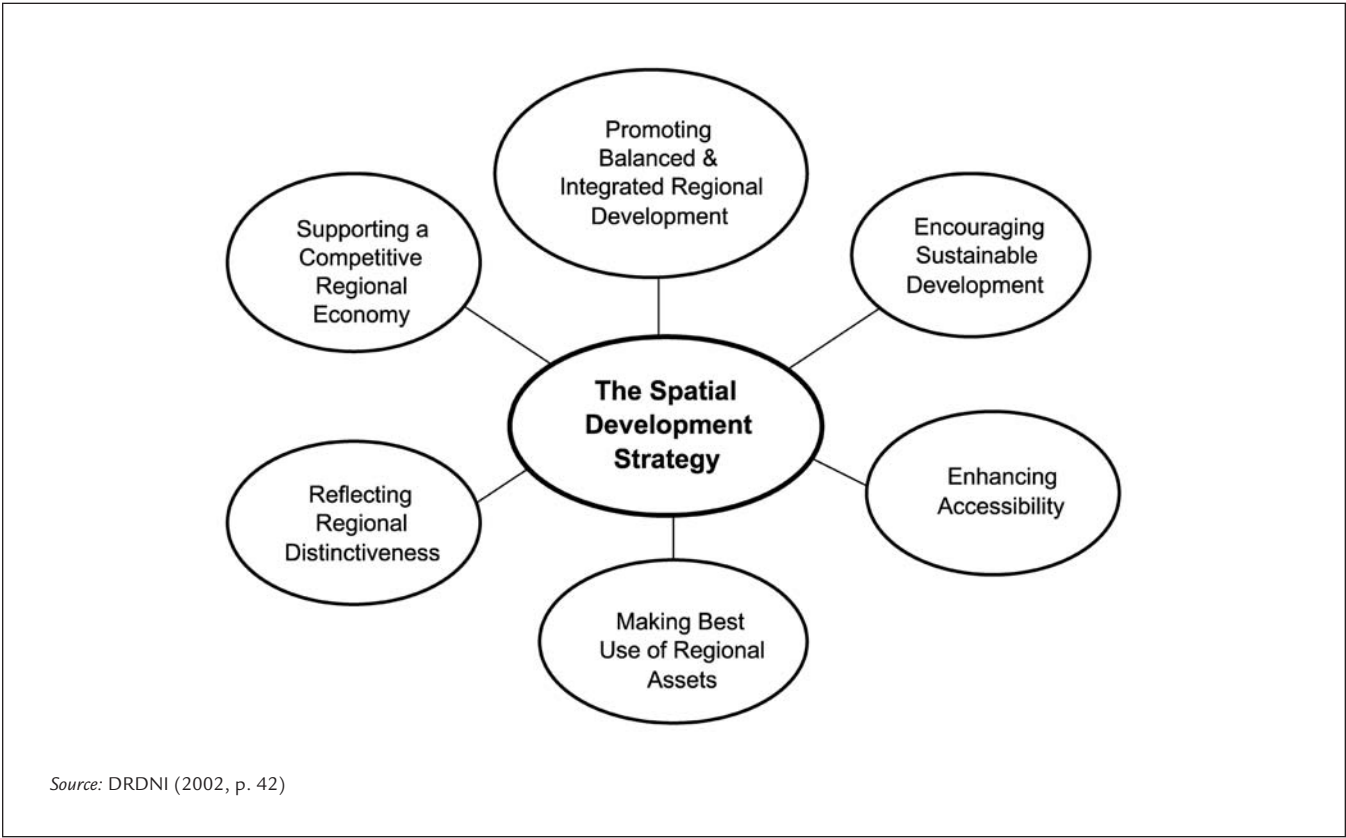


FIGURE 6. Themes of the spatial development strategy in Northern Ireland.

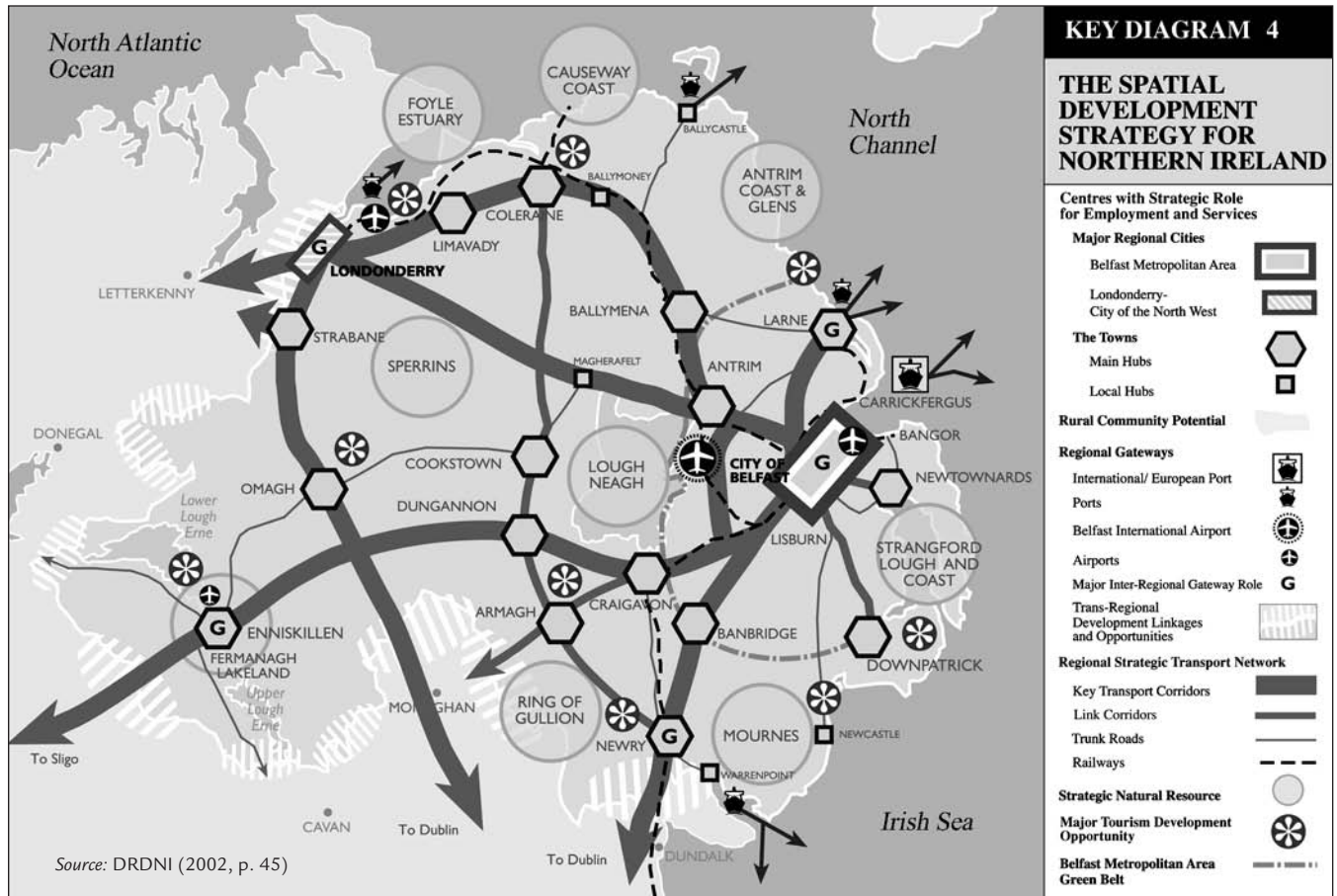


FIGURE 7. Spatial strategy diagram of Northern Ireland.

- the well-developed UK discourses around different planning topics and their treatment in land use regulation.

It nevertheless represents a real effort to overhaul the planning and development agenda in the province and to refocus territorial development policy.

Institutional Arenas and Processes

In the distinctive political context of Northern Ireland, the Northern Ireland Executive gave special attention to processes for articulating a regional development strategy. The Northern Ireland Executive had no local representative legitimacy. It was therefore important to build a constituency for the strategy. The process originated with the planning team in the Northern Ireland Executive. It then spiralled out into intensive consultations, with one major loop encompassing the public sector and well-recognised business lobbies and

another developing a programme of wide-ranging consultation with all kinds of voluntary and community groups, using a range of consultation processes. These inputs were filtered by the planning team and cast into a draft strategy. Until then, no regional-level planning policy document in the UK had been subject to such a high degree of participation. Nor had one been tested in any kind of public inquiry context. To buttress the legitimacy of the strategy as representing a broad base of support within the province, the planning team decided to take the draft strategy through the kind of public examination process required for UK spatial structure plans. It was at this point that local housebuilders became involved. Their pressure initially produced some significant changes to the strategy, notably an increase in the number of dwellings to be accommodated, a reduction in the acreage targeted for brownfield development, and a higher proportion of new dwellings located in the eastern part of the province (Neill & Gordon,

2001). However, this shift was reversed before final approval.

Impacts and Outcomes

The driving force for *Shaping Our Future* has been the political project of moving towards a less fractured society in the context of a power-sharing, devolved government that aims for a new social cohesion that recognises diversity. The strategy has a local motivation and many local characteristics. Its spatial emphasis has real force because it matters politically and at the fine grain where investment goes. But it is also strongly influenced by wider European policy agendas. The European spatial policy discourse, with its spatial vocabulary, provides a way of wrapping a spatial development strategy around the well-established UK approach to policy principles for the regulation of different types of development.

Shaping Our Future deserves the praise it has been given outside Northern Ireland. It has provided a strategic focus for infrastructure investment policy. It has given a framework to localities to work out how to position themselves in a positive way in a new “shared and devolved” political landscape. It has provided a basis for some degree of transdepartmental integration at government level. It has helped to change the governance culture towards more participatory practices. And it has provided a goal-focused, transparent argument about investment priorities in a highly charged political environment. Yet it can also be criticised. Some scholars note the lack of an effective regional economic analysis and criticize the very elaborate development of an integrated strategy, when its impact on investment resources is uncertain and its primary function is to allocate housing quantities among parts of the province (Neill & Gordon, 2001). Its spatial development strategy, though important in rethinking the province in terms of diversity within an integrated approach, nevertheless uses rather traditional spatial concepts (Healey, 2002). Five years after the strategy process started and a year after strategy approval, the critical questions are: How it will be used in the future, and what legacy will its preparation process leave behind? Will its framing of policy and its process innovations endure as the politics of devolved government in the province evolve?

Strategic Spatial Governance: The Learning Environment of European Regions

Despite the claim often made that the agenda of economic competitiveness and European integration has been driving strategic spatial planning initiatives in Eu-

rope, these examples show that this is by no means the dominant direct motivation (see Table 1). Instead, this pressure is transposed into a political project, through a search for ways of strengthening regional identity and cohesion, developing new forms of regional collaboration, and promoting city region profiles internationally. This, in turn, focuses policy attention on the potential of a territorially integrated policy approach, expressed through spatial concepts that can help to reframe policy ideas. In the more affluent contexts of the Hanover and Flanders regions, citizen and pressure group demands for improvements to quality of life and the environment have also been significant, while in Northern Ireland the yearning for peace has been a powerful force underpinning the political use of the vehicle of a regional development strategy. In Northern Ireland, as in other parts of the UK, the European spatial planning discourse articulated through the *ESDP* has also been important, partly because of the political value of the concept of balanced development, partly because of the EU's direct influence through the disbursement of the structural funds for which Northern Ireland is eligible, and partly because of the lack of a rich recent tradition of spatial policy concepts in the UK planning discourse. In Flanders, new planning concepts were drawn down from academic planning discourse, while in Hanover the policy agenda evolved from a rich local tradition.

Lesson 1

These findings highlight the first general lesson to be drawn from the current European experiences. Strategic spatial planning initiatives may look similar in broad outlines, but they take many different forms, performing different kinds of governance work in different contexts. Our examples highlight the importance of the value given to a regional territorial development approach by key local actors and the role of spatial concepts within it, rather than the formulaic translation of general concepts into local arenas. If there are many reasons why such strategies are being undertaken across Europe at present, the lesson is that local responses matter. Those strategies that are both innovative and transformative and are embedded in local perceptions of challenges and opportunities are more likely to have lasting effects.

Lessons 2 and 3

The second lesson from European experience is that initiatives in strategic spatial planning can liberate innovative creative forces, but they can also become exercises in holding on to the status quo. Our examples were selected to illustrate the former, but without continual renewal and adaptation, the strategic frameworks artic-

TABLE 1. Relative importance of driving forces behind European spatial planning initiatives in case studies.

Driving force	Presence		
	Hanover City Region 1996 ^a	Flanders 1997 ^b	Northern Ireland 2001 ^c
Regional “competitiveness”	Weak	Moderate	Weak
Need for budget sharing to offset declining municipal revenues	Strong	None	None
Pressure group concern for quality of life/environment	Moderate	Moderate	Weak (citizens’ hopes for peace)
Political/cultural emphasis on regional identity and cohesion	Weak	Strong	Moderate
Government reorganisation	Strong (city region level)	Weak (state level)	Moderate (state level)
Search for territory-based policy integration	Strong	Strong	Weak
Professional trans-European spatial planning concepts	None	None	Weak
Local response to pressing local problems	Weak	Strong	Strong

a. Spatial Framework for the Hanover City Region 1996.

b. Strategic Spatial Structure Plan for Flanders 1997.

c. Northern Ireland Regional Development Strategy 2001

ulated could regress to the latter. This ambiguous potential of strategic spatial planning arises because of the need to build both strong spatial organising concepts and persuasive institutional alliances to carry a strategy across a diffused power context and through time. A critical task is the formation of policy agendas integrated around some central framing concepts, which can then be translated spatially, so that many parties can grasp the concrete difference it will make to use them. The value of a territorial approach, translated into concepts about spatial organisation and place quality, is that these concrete differences become much more visible. If the concepts begin to gain acceptance among many significant actors, then they are likely to carry substantial power to frame investments and regulatory practices into the future. But this shaping power threatens to close off future opportunity. The challenge for all those supplying expert advice to strategists is to offer clues about how to express a creative, flexible, future-oriented approach in concepts and visions that do not become too concrete and too limiting, but can yet contribute to a politically acceptable way of creating new activity locations while maintaining valued landscapes, resources, and place qualities and generating open and positive notions of local identity.

A third, related lesson is that developing the spatial dimensions of such strategic plans is not just a matter of technical analysis, but the development of spatial logic and metaphors that can command attention and carry persuasive power in complex political contexts, a point made in earlier analyses of the European experience (Faludi, 1996; Neuman, 1997). Currently in Europe, there is a tension between developing a store of such logic and metaphors (as in the discourse around the *ESPD*) and the local invention of organising images (as with the “Flemish Diamond” metaphor).

Lesson 4

A fourth lesson stresses the importance of creating appropriate institutional arenas for these regional spatial development initiatives. In this context, the existence of some institutional inheritance at the regional or sub-regional scale was an important asset in all three cases. It is also helpful if local jurisdictions have some financial autonomy. Across Europe, there is much discussion about how to build such a scale. But an institutional inheritance may be both an asset and a hindrance to introducing new policy ideas and practices. Overcoming resistance means that exercises in introducing new policy agendas and practices should be about creating, to

some degree at least, a new kind of governance culture. This reflects the challenge across Europe. The tradition of strong government at levels above the municipality provides an accepted mode of practice, but it also means that a whole range of policy actors, within and outside government, are locked in to practices that resist new policy ideas and new forms of governance. As these examples show, it is not enough just to rely on exemplar initiatives and informal practices. To have long-lasting and robust effects, efforts to articulate new strategies and practices have to be connected to accountable political levels of government and to formal, legal requirements that affect both regulatory and investment practices. These pieces of “hard” institutional infrastructure themselves carry the power to affect governance cultures.

Lesson 5

A fifth lesson is that such initiatives benefit from the existence and acceptance of a strong role for the state and a strong political consciousness of place identity. Although there are major movements across Europe to make states at all levels more flexible and collaborative, they remain key actors in shaping territorial development. In contrast to the U.S., where government power is more hidden within federal rules and regulations and the very power-dependent legal system, across Europe, state power is still widely accepted by the society as a guarantee of a certain degree of spatial justice.

The potential power of strategic spatial plans and frameworks to affect the future thus lies in several dimensions:

- their capacity to frame concepts and images to mobilise and fix attention,
- their creation of policy discourses through which specific decisions and practices are focused,
- their impact on statutory tools and procedures,
- their creation of expert policy communities that carry new ideas from place to place and enrich local learning capacity, and
- their capacity to shift governance cultures.

Many actors in Europe’s city regions know that the productive use of their regional social, cultural, and environmental assets—their landscape and cities formed over millennia—is a key to their survival in a globalising economy, where corporate market rationales decide the future of locations.

For all these reasons, Europe currently provides a rich laboratory of strategic spatial planning and governance episodes through which planners worldwide can explore the extent and manner of the development of the capacity and influence of strategic spatial planning. Of course, it will take longer to evaluate the outcomes of

such capacity, if it is created. Spatial strategies are not merely long-term in their substantive orientation. Shifting governance cultures is itself a long-term process. But the hope is that where localities are able to achieve such shifts around more creative and flexible spatial strategies and more open, innovative, and collaborative governance practices, this will translate into sustainable and widely shared improvements in quality of life and of environments.

NOTES

1. For more information on this topic, see Bundesamt für Bauwesen und Raumordnung (2001), KGH (2001a, 2001b), Frohner and Prieb (2001), and Prieb (1999, 2002).
2. As elsewhere, business interests tend to criticise planning systems, while they enjoy their benefits.
3. The *Verband Großraum Hannover* (Association of Greater Hanover) was established in 1963, the *Zweckverband Großraum Hannover* (Special Purpose Association of Greater Hanover) in 1980, and the *Kommunalverband Großraum Hannover* (Intercommunal Association of Greater Hanover) in 1992.
4. For more information on this topic, see Ministerie Vlaamse Gemeenschap (1998), Albrechts (1999), and Loeckx (1995).
5. These demands include 400,000 new dwellings (17% of existing stock), an additional 10,000 hectares of industrial land, and infrastructure to accommodate substantial increases in passenger and freight traffic.
6. *Deconcentrated* refers to the highly fragmented existing spatial structure. *Clustering* refers to the new policy of concentrating growth. This echoes the much used German concept of *deconcentrated concentration*.
7. The image of a diamond was consciously chosen for the polycentric city region in central Belgium. It recalls one of the strengths of the Flemish economy and shows that the area is the “core” of Flanders. This “bright” image was used to reflect the potentials of the network. The image also depicts the individual cities (such as Brussels, Antwerp, Ghent, and Leuven) as the “facets,” each contributing to the quality of the network. The image makes it clear that purposeful action (cutting and polishing of the diamond) is needed to reveal the full potential of the network.
8. Most plans in Belgium have traditionally been prepared by consultants.
9. For more information on this topic, see DRDNI (2002), Healey (2002), McEldowney and Sterrett (2001), and Neill and Gordon (2001).
10. It was launched by the UK Secretary of State for Northern Ireland in June 1997, just after the election of the UK’s New Labour government, which was committed to speeding up the peace process. It was also mentioned in the 1998 “Good Friday Agreement” that resulted in the formation of a devolved, elected regional government in the province.

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